

Approval Procedure

ASI-PRO-20-258 - Version 2.1

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1. PURPOSE AND SCOPE

- 1.1 This procedure applies to Assurance Services International (ASI) Approval Processes of Conformity Assessment Bodies (CABs) for Scheme Owners (SOs) under the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program (TTAP).
- 1.2 This procedure describes the general Approval process of ASI for Tier Two. It specifies the requirements for CABs seeking to apply for and maintain ASI Approval. It covers processes such as Approval application, maintenance, reapproval, scope extension and reduction, transfer, Suspension and Withdrawal of Approval.
- 1.3 This procedure explains the duties and responsibilities of ASI and CABs (approved and applicant) during the Approval Cycle. It applies to all Approval activities and is binding for all parties involved in the process of Approval.
- 1.4 Other applicable operational activities and responsibilities of ASI and CABs are described in additional supporting ASI procedures and Approval Requirements.
- 1.5 Participating Accreditation Bodies (ABs) have their own requirements and processes, which are not repeated in this procedure and adherence to these requirements underpinning a valid Accreditation status is a requirement for ASI Approval Decisions.

2. CHANGE HISTORY

Version number	Date of approval	Effective date	Description of changes
1.0	15/09/2023	15/09/2023	First publication based on Accreditation Procedure ASI-PRO-20-101 - Version 5.1 (08/12/2020); fully adopting the Two-Tier Assurance Program.
1.1	22/11/2023	22/11/2023	Minor changes in clause 10.3 for applicant CABs, (changed from 30 to 60 days to process new applications)
2.0	27/03/2023	01/05/2023	Minor revision: Addition/replacement of term Challenges (formerly Level 1 Appeals) to match new terminology in procedure Challenges & Appeals. Changes to Suspension section (clarification of conditions under clause 20.4). Removal of 30-day embargo for publishing suspension and withdrawal decisions. Refinement of Application process to align more precisely with other ASI procedures. Additional clause 13.4 for additional conditions during decision processes. Additional clauses (19.4 & 19.5) and term Show Cause Notice to align with new IAF MD7:2023 and IAF ID 15:2023 to allow entities to provide evidence to refute fraud allegations before imposing a Sanction or to take actions if fraud is detected at CH level.
2.1	10/04/2024	10/04/2024	Format changes to match new ASI branding. No further content changes. Replacement of reference from Sampling Procedure to the new Oversight Procedure (ASI-PRO-20-260).

3. TERMS AND DEFINITIONS

3.1 All terms and definitions, where not defined below, are provided in the ASI Glossary ([ASI-INF-20-100](#))

3.2 **ASI Approval (Decision):** ASI confirmation that the CAB complies with the ASI Approval Requirements and SO Requirements and can provide certification services within their Scope of Approval, provided that the CAB also holds a valid Accreditation from a Participating AB as per the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program.

Explanatory Note [SOURCE: IAF MD 25]: SO Authorization of a CAB: SO authorization means that the SO accepts certificates, reports, statements or attestations issued by a CAB for the purposes of confirming that the object of the conformity assessment meets the requirements of its Conformity Assessment Scheme (CAS). SOs may use different wording to denote/state/describe authorization, such as listing, approval, recognition, designation, etc.

3.3 **ASI Approval Certificate:** Certificate issued by ASI to confirm compliance with the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program.

3.4 **ASI Approval Requirements:** Those requirements which are set up by ASI and which the CAB has to fulfill to qualify for being approved to a Certification Scheme and for maintaining such approval. These are contained in the documents (information documents, policies, procedures and templates) listed in ASI-INF-20-120 'Controlled List of Public ASI QMS Documents' and published on ASI's website (www.asi-assurance.org/s/quality).

3.5 **ASI North America PB LLC (ASI NA):** A wholly owned subsidiary with limited liabilities of FSC AC, constituted as Delaware LLC, the Participating AB appointed to accredit CABs with head offices based outside the EEA and UK.

3.6 **ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program (TTAP):** The ASI program that integrates Accreditation (Tier One) and complementary ASI Assurance Services (Tier Two) to ensure the overall integrity for Scheme Owners and their claims:

⇒ **Tier One:** Consists of the Accreditation of Conformity Assessment Bodies (CABs) by Participating Accreditation Bodies (Participating ABs) with mandatory ASI participation in Accreditation Assessments, leading to an Accreditation Decision.

⇒ **Tier Two:** Consists of the complementary Assurance Services provided by ASI, leading to an ASI Approval Decision.

3.7 **Approval Report:** Report summarizing ASI evaluation results and confirming if the CAB complies with the Scheme Owner Requirements and ASI Approval Requirements for Tier Two.

3.8 **Assurance Services:** Any and all independent and impartial ASI Assessment or other relevant activities that ensure the integrity of Scheme Owner's systems and their claims.

3.9 **Participating Accreditation Body (Participating AB):** An Accreditation Body operating under the framework of (EC) 765/2008 in the European Economic Area (EEA) and of UKAS operating under the regulation on Accreditation and Market Surveillance No 765:2008 (GB RAMS) in the UK and ASI North America PB LLC that has established a cooperation with ASI to provide Accreditation for any of the Scheme Owners under the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program.

- 3.10 **Scheme Owners** (also ASI Client VSS): ASI partner Voluntary Sustainability Standards (VSS) and sustainability initiatives, which have exclusively appointed ASI to provide Assurance Services on their behalf under the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program.
- 3.11 **Scheme Owner (SO) Requirements:** Those Requirements which are set up by the Scheme Owner of the relevant Scheme, with which CABs have to comply in order to provide the relevant certification services. These are contained in documents (e.g. standards, policies, procedures, advice notes etc.) published by the Scheme Owner. As far as these documents incorporate other publicly available documents by reference (e.g. ISO standards), further requirements set up in such other documents are also considered part of the SO Requirements.
- 3.12 **Show cause notice:** An order issued by ASI which requires an entity about which an allegation has been made, which can be a CAB or a CH, to provide evidence in writing to contest allegations of fraud within a specific timeline, otherwise, Sanctions may be recommended.

4. EFFECTIVE DATE

This procedure shall be effective on **01 April 2024**

5. ASSOCIATED DOCUMENTATION

The following documents are indispensable for the application of this document.

5.1	Standards and Policies	Applicable Scheme Owner requirements
5.2	Procedures, Guidelines	All ASI documents listed in section 4 of ASI-INF-20-120 'Controlled List of Public ASI QMS Documents' and published on ASI's website
5.3	Checklists, Templates, etc.	ASI Service Agreement ASI-TPL-20-244-ASI Two-Tier Application Form ASI-TPL-20-216-Scope Extension & Reduction Application Form CHK-20-203-Accreditation Transfer

6. GENERAL

- 6.1 ASI runs the TTAP and therein carries out Approval activities, following appointment of ASI by the relevant SO.
- 6.2 ASI Approval follows a decision-making process that is not dependent on decisions taken by any other party. However, ASI has concluded agreements with Participating ABs under the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program which explicitly describe the roles and responsibilities of the parties involved and defines how each party shall bring relevant CAB conformance information to each other's attention for review and consideration.
- 6.3 Participating ABs follow their own Accreditation processes, leading to their respective accreditation decisions, which are not repeated in this procedure.
- 6.4 ASI Assessment results are administered through the ASI Assurance Management System (AMS). The CAB is granted access to the AMS via the CAB Portal. ASI and the CAB shall maintain and keep up to date all communication and Assessment information in the CAB Portal.

7. SCOPE OF APPROVAL

- 7.1 The Scope of Approval refers to the area(s) of competence for which a CAB's certification activity is covered by ASI Approval. The scope of Approval (Tier Two) in the ASI Approval certificate and annex specifies the following:

- 7.1.1 Scheme Owner;
- 7.1.2 type of activities and/or products covered (ASI technical scope);
- 7.1.3 standards and/or other normative documents and mandatory requirements with respect to the activities, services, products and/or systems that are certified;
- 7.1.4 geographical area in which the Certification Activities are approved (ASI geographical scope).

NOTE: The Scope of Accreditation (Tier One) is granted by the Participating AB on the related Accreditation Certificate.

8. APPROVAL REQUIREMENTS

- 8.1 Approval shall only be granted and maintained if the CAB (applicant or approved) commits to continually fulfill the ASI Approval Requirements and to provide evidence of such fulfillment. This refers to both the ASI Approval Requirements and the SO Requirements of any Certification Scheme and scope for which Approval is sought or granted.
- 8.2 The CAB shall comply with:
- 8.2.1 The SO Requirements as defined in the normative documents of the respective SO.
 - 8.2.2 The ASI Approval Requirements published in the ASI Controlled List of Public Documents (ASI-INF-20-120).
 - 8.2.3 Participating AB requirements for Accreditation under Tier One.
- 8.3 In the case that the SO has not defined SO Requirements or ASI determines the need for additional requirements, ASI reserves the right to develop its own ASI Approval Requirements for the respective Scheme to be able to carry out the work expected from ASI as agreed with the SO.
- 8.4 ASI shall only consider published official SO interpretations of SO Requirements and not individual interpretations.

9. GENERAL ASSESSMENT REQUIREMENTS

The following requirements are applicable to all types of ASI Assurance Assessments under Tier Two of the TTAP.

- 9.1 ASI shall allocate an Assessor or team of Assessors for each Assessment. An Assessment Team may include a team leader, co-Assessors, trainees, Technical Experts, facilitators and translators. Observers may join an Assessment, if previously agreed by the CAB, but they are not considered part of the team.
- 9.2 Before each Assessment, ASI shall inform the CAB about the Assessment Team composition and any Observers.
- 9.2.1 The CAB may submit a written objection against Observers within 5 calendar days of notification from ASI.

- 9.2.2 The CAB may submit a written objection against team member(s) in the case of existing or perceived Conflict of Interest (COI) within 5 calendar days of notification from ASI about the team composition and shall include objective evidence to support any claims made.
- 9.2.3 ASI shall review the objection(s) and may change the team composition if deemed justifiable, to mitigate or eliminate existing or perceived COI.
- 9.2.4 Due to timelines, CAB objections against Assessment Teams used in Short Notice and Unannounced Assessments may not be possible.
- 9.2.5 Notification of the ASI team for Witness Assessments is dependent on the CAB informing ASI in a timely manner about the CAB audit dates.
- 9.3 All Head Office (HO), Affiliate Office (AO), Witness and Compliance Assessments shall start with an opening meeting. For Desk Review, the CAB shall be given an opportunity to request an opening meeting.
- 9.4 All Assessments, including Desk Reviews, shall be concluded with a closing meeting. If there is disagreement regarding any of the findings, they should be discussed and resolved at the closing meeting if possible. If not resolved, the disagreement shall be noted in the Summary of Findings (SOF) and in the final Assessment Report. The CAB is encouraged to involve their senior management in opening and closing meetings.
- 9.5 Opening and closing meetings may be held remotely if needed, with previous agreement of both parties.
- 9.6 ASI Assessment Report timelines for all Assessment types are given in calendar days and start at the closing meeting (see Figure 1).
- 9.6.1 ASI shall share a SOF within 5 calendar days of the closing meeting and the CAB shall have 10 calendar days upon receipt of the SOF to file any Errors of Fact (EOF).
- 9.6.2 All reports undergo a Technical Review (TR) and a sign-off process and because of these, the grading and wording of findings may change between the SOF and the final report. Any changes shall be indicated in the final Assessment Report.
- 9.6.3 ASI shall share a final Assessment Report with the CAB within 40 calendar days of the Assessment closing meeting.
- Figure 1: ASI Assessment Report Timelines (in calendar days)**
-
- | Event | Duration (calendar days) |
|-----------------|--------------------------|
| Closing meeting | Day 0 |
| SOF | • 5 days |
| EOF | • 10 days |
| Draft Report | • 10 days |
| TR | • 5 days |
| Final report | • 5 days |
| Sign-off | • 5 days |
- 9.7 All ASI findings shall be handled as described in the ASI Findings Procedure (ASI-PRO-20-106).
- 9.8 The CAB shall facilitate and cooperate in all ASI Assessments to ensure a constructive and professional Assessment environment.
- 9.8.1 The CAB shall provide unrestricted access to premises and documentation that pertain to the certification process, their operations and Scope of Approval.
- 9.8.2 Access to premises and documentation shall be provided for all members of the ASI team. Such access shall also include AOs, if ASI determines this is necessary.
- 9.8.3 The CAB shall have at all times written and legally enforceable arrangements with a) their clients (certificate holders and applicants for certification), b) Subcontractors/Affiliate Offices and c) all other entities and/or personnel involved in

the certification activities carried out under this Agreement to ensure ASI has access to the client's site and relevant documents.

10. APPLICATION

- 10.1 Information about the application process, including the application form, is available on the ASI website.
- 10.2 The applicant CAB shall be a legal entity that performs Conformity Assessment Services.
- 10.3 Applications shall be made electronically via the form on the ASI website or, in the case of technical or accessibility issues, via the ASI application form.
- 10.4 All information requested by ASI, including the application and supporting documentation (application package), shall be completed in English.
- 10.5 The CAB shall submit an ASI application form and Business Partner Integrity Questionnaire (BPIQ) to ASI.
- 10.6 ASI shall acknowledge receipt and conduct a screening of the application and supporting documentation within 10 calendar days of its receipt.
 - 10.6.1 Additional information and/or clarification may be requested from the applicant. Incomplete applications may be rejected.
- 10.7 If the application is complete, ASI shall evaluate the information submitted within 60 calendar days of receiving the complete application. If the application is rejected, ASI shall provide a justification. ASI shall reject the application if:
 - 10.7.1 At any time during the application or initial Assessment process, there is evidence of fraudulent behavior;
 - 10.7.2 The applicant intentionally provides false information or conceals information;
 - 10.7.3 Any known violation of laws and regulations by the CAB would bring ASI into disrepute;
 - 10.7.4 There is lack of compliance by the CAB with local regulations and legal requirements in the country or region of operation;
 - 10.7.5 There are regulatory or safety restrictions that would impede ASI's implementation of the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program; or
 - 10.7.6 The ASI due diligence review reveals that the risk posed by a business relationship with the applicant is too high.
- 10.8 If a CAB wishes to reapply for the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program after a rejection, a new application shall be submitted, and a new application fee paid. ASI may impose a cooldown period of up to two years before considering a new application from a rejected entity.
- 10.9 Upon acceptance of the application, the CAB shall:
 - 10.9.1 Sign the ASI Assurance Service Agreement and,
 - 10.9.2 Complete the scheme specific checklists shared by ASI and return it with supporting documentation prior to the beginning of a Desk Review.
- 10.10 The CAB shall inform ASI in writing if, during the application process, the CAB decides not to pursue Approval and to withdraw from the process.

- 10.11 ASI may propose a reduced Scope of Approval, based on the results of relevant evaluations or Assessments.
- 10.12 Changes to the Approval scope requested in the original application form are only possible if the CAB submits a formal scope extension/reduction application.
- 10.13 In the case of significant changes in any aspect of the applicant's status or operations during the application process, ASI may request the applicant to submit a new application and to pay a new application fee. Significant changes may include changes to CAB structure or procedures which require the review of new documents and processes and thus increased ASI evaluation time.

11. INITIAL APPROVAL EVALUATION

- 11.1 ASI shall conduct a Desk Review of the CAB application and documentation to determine if the documentation meets the applicable ASI Approval Requirements and SO Requirements and if they have been integrated into the CAB's Management System and procedures.
- 11.2 Once Major NC(s), if any, from the Desk Review have been closed as per the ASI Findings Procedure (ASI-PRO-20-106), ASI shall issue an Initial Approval Letter to the CAB.
 - 11.2.1 ASI places the name of applicant CABs on the ASI website following the closure of all Major NCs from the initial Desk Review. From that moment onwards, the applicant may advertise their status as an applicant, inform any clients or potential clients of their applicant status and use the ASI trademark as outlined in the ASI Trademark Policy ([ASI-POL-20-108](#)).
- 11.3 The CAB shall apply to the relevant Participating AB for initial Accreditation or for Accreditation scope extension (if the CAB is already accredited for ISO 17065 or ISO 17021). The CAB shall give the AB a copy of the Initial Approval Letter for consideration and follow the AB processes.
- 11.4 The CAB shall undergo Accreditation Assessments conducted by the Participating AB, with the mandatory participation of ASI Assessors.
- 11.5 ASI may decide to conduct other Assurance Services to evaluate the CAB, before preparing an Approval Report (see 11.7).
- 11.6 The applicant CAB shall respond to any requests for clarification, additional documents and/or information and to any NCs within the deadlines indicated by ASI.
- 11.7 If after considering the results of ASI's evaluation and the CAB's management of NCs (including closure of all Major NCs), ASI concludes that the CAB's certification system meets all SO Requirements, ASI shall prepare an Approval Report recommending ASI Approval.
- 11.8 The Participating AB shall consider the ASI Approval Report prior to making its Accreditation Decision. After the Participating AB has issued the Accreditation Certificate, ASI shall issue an Approval Certificate and the CAB may start providing certification services under the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program.
- 11.9 If the applicant CAB is unable to achieve Approval within two years of ASI's receipt of the application, ASI shall stop and cancel the Approval process. A full reapplication may be required in such instances.

12. ERRORS OF FACT

- 12.1 The CAB is given the opportunity to file Errors of Fact (EOF) for:
 - 12.1.1 ASI findings via the CAB Portal upon receipt of the SOF after each Assessment (for further details see ASI Findings Procedure (ASI-PRO-20-106)); and
 - 12.1.2 Approval Reports via email upon receipt of the draft report before the Approval Decision.
- 12.2 The deadline to file EOF is 10 calendar days from the date that the draft Approval Report is shared with the CAB. ASI may grant an extension of the deadline if the CAB sends a written request via email before the deadline, including an objective justification explaining why the CAB is not able to file EOF within the original timeline.
- 12.3 ASI shall provide a response to all EOF which have been provided within the deadlines specified in clause 12.2. Any amendments to the report that are considered justified by ASI shall be applied before the Approval Report is finalized.
- 12.4 If EOF are not filed within the deadline (or, in case of an extension, within the extended deadline), all facts contained or omitted in the SOF or Approval Reports shall be considered true and accurate unless it is or becomes obvious that the information is untrue. As far as the factual basis for a decision is considered accurate in this regard, the CAB shall not appeal or otherwise challenge the decision later, based on the allegation that statements of facts are not accurate.

13. APPROVAL DECISIONS

- 13.1 Depending on the decision type, Approval Decisions are taken by the ASI Approval Committee (ApC), Program Managers (PMs) or by the ASI Operations Director (OD). The OD may delegate a decision to a deputy (see Table 1 below).
- 13.2 ASI shall prepare an Approval Report and supporting documentation for the following Decisions: Initial Approval, Technical scope extension/reduction, Geographical scope reduction, Suspension, Lifting of Suspension and Withdrawal.
- 13.3 If the CAB files EOF according to clause 12.1 above, ASI shall provide these together with the Approval Report to the decision maker.
- 13.4 For all Approval Decisions, ASI may specify additional requirements and conditions for CABs to manage ongoing risks to the integrity of their Approval.
- 13.5 The CAB may appeal Approval Decisions in accordance with the ASI Challenge & Appeals Procedure (ASI-PRO-20-103).
- 13.6 The CAB shall only be permitted to contest an Approval Decision on the basis that a fact contained in the SOF or Approval Report is untrue if an EOF has been filed against that fact within the deadlines described above.
- 13.7 Failure of ASI to comply with a procedural provision does not necessarily render an Approval Decision invalid. If ASI fails to comply with a procedural provision, the process shall be revisited to ensure that all such provisions are followed.

Table 1 - Decision types & responsible decision makers

Table 1 – Decision types & responsible decision makers			
Decision type	Decision-making responsible person/s	Deadline for decision-making	Deadline for ASI notification to CAB
Initial Approval	OD	30 calendar days from receipt of Approval Report, where Participating AB decision has been made*	5 calendar days from decision
Maintenance of Approval	PMs	Recommendation within Final Assessment report	Final Assessment report
Renewing cycle (Reapproval)	OD	30 calendar days from latest CPR, where Participating AB decision has been made*	5 calendar days from decision
Technical Scope Extension	OD	30 calendar days from receipt of Approval Report, where Participating AB decision has been made*	
Technical Scope Reduction	ApC	30 calendar days from receipt of Approval Report	
Geographical Scope extension	OD	Recommendation within Final Assessment report	
Geographical Scope Reduction	ApC	30 calendar days from receipt of Approval Report	
Suspension	ApC	10 calendar days from receipt of Approval Report	
Lifting Suspension	ApC		
Withdrawal	ApC	30 calendar days from receipt of Approval Report	
CAB voluntary scope Reduction, Suspension or Withdrawal	OD	10 calendar days from receipt of CAB request	

* If Participating AB decision has not been made, Approval decision shall be delayed until this is done

14. NOTIFICATION OF APPROVAL

- 14.1 Approval is granted in the form of an Approval Certificate and annex that marks the start of the first Approval Cycle. This shall be adjusted where necessary to harmonize with the Participating AB Accreditation (maximum five years).
- 14.2 A new certificate shall only be issued if there are changes in CAB name, address or Approved Scheme. In the case of geographical or technical scope changes, only the certificate annex shall be updated to reflect this change.
- 14.3 ASI shall add the CAB to the ASI list of approved CABs on its website alongside the corresponding Participating AB Accreditation, specifying for which scopes the Approval applies.

15. MAINTAINING APPROVAL

- 15.1 ASI monitors and evaluates the CAB's competence and Conformity throughout the Approval Cycle. Each year, ASI shall provide the Approved CAB with an Oversight Plan for the upcoming surveillance year in line with the ASI Oversight Procedure (ASI-PRO-20-260).

- 15.2 ASI may publish announcements of Assessments for approved CABs on its website and carry out stakeholder consultation. ASI shall consider stakeholder comments and respond to these while ensuring stakeholder confidentiality.
- 15.3 ASI may conduct Extra Assessments to investigate Incidents and/or Complaints or the outcome of an earlier Assessment or under other circumstances as deemed necessary by ASI.
- 15.4 ASI may conduct Unannounced Assessments as part of or outside of its surveillance Assessment program in order to address heightened risk or allegations of serious violations of ASI Approval Requirements or SO Requirements.
- 15.5 The CAB shall ensure that ASI is able to conduct Witness and Compliance Assessments of the sample of CAB clients selected by ASI. Further details on selection criteria and scope are given in the Witness & Compliance Assessment Procedure (ASI-PRO-20-111).

16. REAPPROVAL

- 16.1 The objective of the Reapproval is to renew the Approval Cycle, confirm the ongoing competence of the CAB and evaluate the CAB's management and Certification systems.
 - 16.1.1 All major NCs with a deadline for closure within one month of the end of the Approval Cycle shall be closed.
 - 16.1.2 Other open NCs shall not delay the reapproval process unless they raise serious questions about the CAB's competence to carry out Certification Activities or pose a risk to the validity of Certification decision-making.
- 16.2 Once all major and other critical NCs are addressed as described in 16.1, ASI shall renew the approval cycle based on the following information:
 - 16.2.1 Results from the latest ASI CAB Performance Review (see the ASI Appraisal Procedure (ASI-PRO-20-256).
 - 16.2.2 Reaccreditation decision by participating AB.
- 16.3 If ASI decides in favor of reapproval, ASI shall notify the CAB within 5 calendar days of the decision.
- 16.4 ASI shall issue a Sanction (see Section 19) against the CAB if the Approval Cycle expires before the decision-making process can be finished due to a CAB failure to demonstrate conformance with 16.1.1 and 16.1.2.
- 16.5 If the Approval Cycle expires before the decision-making process can be finished for reasons beyond CAB control, the CAB's Approval shall remain valid.
- 16.6 If ASI decides against Reapproval, ASI shall notify the CAB within 5 calendar days of the decision, of the basis for the decision and any next steps on behalf of the CAB and ASI. The CAB may appeal the decision in accordance with the ASI Challenge & Appeals Procedure (ASI-PRO-20-103).

17. SCOPE EXTENSION

- 17.1 Technical and geographical scope extensions shall only occur upon CAB request.

- 17.2 Applications shall be made electronically via the ASI CAB Portal or, in the case of technical or accessibility issues, via the Scope Extension and Reduction Application Form (ASI-TPL-20-216).
- 17.3 For technical scope extensions, the CAB shall follow section 11 - Initial Approval Evaluation.
- 17.4 For geographical scope extensions, the following process shall be applied:
- 17.4.1 The CAB is required to provide evidence that it has access to sufficient resources to manage the geographical scope(s), including personnel, languages, Management Systems, AOs or subcontractors, arrangements to cover potential liabilities from conformity assessment activities in the newly proposed countries.
 - 17.4.2 ASI may specify additional conditions during the geographical scope extension to monitor CAB expansion activities and the sufficient access to resources to ensure there are no risks to the integrity of the issued Approval.
 - 17.4.3 ASI may decide not to conduct an additional Assessment if:
 - 1) an Approval Decision can be made based on current knowledge of a CAB's system if it is accredited for other ASI programs;
 - 2) the scope extension is minor (e.g. a country in a region where the CAB already operates); or
 - 3) there is an upcoming Assessment at which this can be evaluated.
- 17.5 Upon a favorable scope extension decision, ASI shall upload a revised certificate annex to the ASI website including the new technical and/or geographical scope and share the revised digital version with the CAB via email.

18. SCOPE REDUCTION

- 18.1 Technical and geographical scope reductions may occur upon ASI recommendation or upon CAB voluntary request.
- 18.2 ASI may recommend a scope reduction to the CAB based on evidence from one or more Assessments or from lack of compliance with local regulations in the country of operations.
- 18.3 A CAB may voluntarily reduce its Scope of Approval for all or for parts of its technical and/or geographical scope by notifying ASI three months in advance of the desired Effective Date of the Reduction of Scope. The consequences of a Reduction of Scope are the same to those of a Withdrawal (see section 21 below).
- 18.4 A CAB that has voluntarily reduced its Scope of Approval may re-apply to extend the scope again at any time, by following the process set out in section 17.

19. SANCTIONS

- 19.1 If a CAB fails to demonstrate conformance with the ASI Approval Requirements and/or SO Requirements or is/has been in breach of the terms of the ASI Assurance Service Agreement (ASA), ASI may impose Sanctions on the CAB. ASI further reserves the right to exercise any rights provided by the law or by the ASA or any other agreement concluded with the CAB.

NOTE: ASI shall inform the relevant Participating AB of an imposed Sanction which may lead to further Sanctions as part of their procedures.

- 19.2 Sanctions are, in order of least to most severity:

- 19.2.1 Formal warning;
 - 19.2.2 Intensification of surveillance of CAB activity (frequency or duration) at the expense of the CAB;
 - 19.2.3 Suspension of Approval (see section 20 below);
 - 19.2.4 Withdrawal of Approval (see section 21 below).
- 19.3 If a Sanction is imposed, the CAB is obliged to provide an analysis of the cause(s) that led to the Sanction, which may serve as a basis for addressing and eliminating the imposed Sanction. If the CAB fails to comply with this obligation, ASI shall impose another Sanction which shall be more severe than the previous one (e.g. after a formal warning, an intensification of surveillance or a Suspension may be imposed).
- 19.4 ASI shall issue a Show Cause Notice as a preliminary step before a Sanction is imposed when there are allegations of fraud to allow the alleged entity to provide evidence to refute the allegations within 10 days of the notice received.
- 19.5 CABs shall take actions to preserve the integrity of the Scheme by withdrawing or limiting certification where appropriate or when requested by ASI, if evidence of fraud is detected or if fraud allegations could not be refuted at the CH level. Failure to comply with this may result in sanctions from ASI.
- 19.6 The following table contains examples of situations leading to Sanctions and the minimal Sanctions which shall be imposed by ASI, as well as the typical progression of Sanctions. ASI may impose an initial Sanction less severe than the minimal Sanction listed in the table if warranted by the particular circumstances of the individual case. ASI may also impose an initial Sanction more severe than the minimal Sanction listed in the table if warranted by the particular circumstances of the individual case.

NOTE: All Suspensions may lead to Withdrawal of Approval if the cause for Suspension is not satisfactorily resolved within the allotted time.

Table 2: Examples of situations leading to Sanctions

Situations leading to Sanctions	Minimal Sanction and typical progression
1) Lack of collaboration in providing information as defined in section 23 of this procedure.	Formal warning → Intensification of surveillance → Suspension
2) Lack of collaboration with scheduling or undergoing ASI Assessments.	Formal warning → Intensification of surveillance → Suspension
3) Improper use of the certificate of Approval or of the ASI logo and Approval symbol (ASI-POL-20-108).	Formal warning → Suspension
4) Non-payment of ASI fees as per section 22 of this procedure.	Formal warning → financial probation → Suspension due to non-payment of fees
5) Discrediting or damaging the reputation of ASI and/or its SOs (e.g. making or supporting incorrect public negative and/or incorrect criticizing statements about ASI and SO systems, processes and teams).	Suspension → Withdrawal
6) Recommendations from one Assessment (beyond NCs) or from the Approval or reapproval process based on evaluation of CAB performance and their compliance with Approval requirements. For example: a) An Assessment recommending Suspension. b) PM recommending Suspension in the Approval Report. c) The ApC recommending Suspension within their review.	Intensification of surveillance → Suspension

7) Failure to submit RCA, Correction and planned Corrective Actions for NCs within the specified deadlines (ref. ASI-PRO-20-106).	Formal warning → Suspension
8) Failure to implement effective Corrections and/or Corrective Actions, thereby not allowing ASI to close a major NC within the specified deadlines (ref. ASI-PRO-20-106).	Formal warning → Suspension
9) Failure to comply with clause 16.1.1 or 16.1.2 of this procedure for the reapproval process (closed major NCs)	Suspension
10) Serious breach of Approval Requirements. For example, but not limited to: a) Offering Certification Activities outside the ASI Scope of Approval; b) Not ensuring clear impartiality of Certification Activities; c) Providing consultancy (paid or unpaid) during the certification process; d) Violation of restrictions imposed during a Suspension (e.g. issue new Certifications)	Suspension or Withdrawal
11) Performing Certification Activities/services in a region without satisfying the necessary legal requirements (e.g. local laws, permits, etc.)	Scope reduction, Suspension or Withdrawal
12) Negligent provision of false information or non-disclosure of information by a CAB.	Suspension → Withdrawal
13) Willful deceit of ASI by intentional submission of false and/or concealment of information needed for ASI to implement its Approval process.	Show cause notice → Withdrawal
14) Evidence of fraudulent behavior, such as fraudulent Audits or Certification decisions.	Show cause notice → Withdrawal
15) Breach of obligations in ASI Assurance Service Agreement	Formal warning → Suspension or Withdrawal
16) Failure to correct the conditions that led to Suspension within the deadlines established.	Withdrawal
17) Suspension of Accreditation by a Participating AB	Suspension → Withdrawal

20. SUSPENSION OF APPROVAL

- 20.1 Suspension places temporary restrictions on the services a CAB may provide within the Scope of Approval. Suspension may be for all or part of the Scope of Approval. The temporary restrictions shall be specified in the notice of Suspension from ASI.
- 20.2 During the Suspension, the CAB shall continue to conduct surveillance and recertification Audits necessary to maintain existing Certifications and shall continue to address open NCs;
- 20.3 Within the scope of the Suspension, the CAB shall not:
- 20.3.1 issue any new ASI Certificate within the Scope of Approval
 - 20.3.2 issue any new scope extension (no addition of sites to existing certificates).
 - 20.3.3 enter into new agreements for Certification. An understanding may be reached with potential clients, but no agreement may be signed and no part of the application process may be undertaken until the Suspension has been lifted.
- 20.4 The CAB may continue to conduct Audits required for initial certification but shall not issue any new ASI approved Certifications or scope extensions within the scope of the Suspension unless the certification process began prior to the date of Suspension and the CAB has obtained prior written approval from ASI.

- 20.5 ASI shall continue to conduct Assurance Services for a CAB and its clients throughout the period of a CAB's Suspension.
- 20.6 Fees paid shall not be refunded upon Suspension. Annual fees shall be paid normally during the period of Suspension.
- 20.7 For Assessment-related Suspensions, the CAB shall be informed about a possible Suspension upon receipt of the final Assessment Report at the latest.
- 20.8 For non-Assessment-related Suspensions (e.g. not responding to major NCs in time), the CAB shall be informed by receiving a formal notification specifying the intent to suspend and the beginning of the Suspension process.
- 20.9 For each Suspension decision (except for non-payment of fees - see section 22), ASI shall prepare an Approval Report for the ApC explaining the reasons leading to Suspension, a justification of the scope (technical and/or geographical) proposed for Suspension, the conditions for lifting the Suspension and any other relevant information considered material for the recommendation.
- 20.10 Before the Approval Report is sent to the ApC, the CAB shall have the opportunity to file EOF to the Approval Report according to timelines specified in clause 12.1.
- 20.11 Within 10 calendar days of receipt of the report, the ApC shall communicate its decision.
- 20.12 Within 5 calendar days of the decision of the ApC, ASI shall notify the CAB of the Suspension in writing. The notice of Suspension shall include the Effective Date of Suspension, duration, reasons, scope and conditions or any additional actions and deadlines for conformance required by the CAB.
- 20.13 The CAB may appeal the Suspension decision in accordance with the ASI Challenge & Appeals Procedure (ASI-PRO-20-103).
- 20.14 ASI shall update the record of Approved CABs on its website and publish a news item and short summary of the grounds for Suspension. The CAB and the SO shall be given an opportunity to review the wording of the news item.
- 20.15 A Suspension shall be effective for a maximum period of six months. The suspended CAB may request an extension of this period with a clear justification to ASI. The extension shall be approved by the OD if the justification is accepted.
- 20.16 Failure to satisfactorily address the causes that led to Suspension within the specified deadline is grounds for initiating Withdrawal of Approval.
- 20.17 Suspension shall be lifted after ASI has verified (e.g. via Assessment) that the conditions specified in the notice of Suspension have been adequately met.
- 20.18 For lifting Suspension, an Approval Report shall be prepared and submitted to the ApC to issue a decision within 10 calendar days of receipt of the report. This report shall not be shared with the CAB to file EOF.
- 20.19 Within 5 calendar days of the decision of the ApC, ASI shall notify the CAB in writing. Once the Suspension has been lifted, ASI shall update the record of approved CABs on its website and inform the SO.

21. WITHDRAWAL OF APPROVAL

- 21.1 ASI shall prepare an Approval Report for the ApC explaining the reasons leading to Withdrawal and any other relevant information considered material for the recommendation.
- 21.2 Before the Approval Report is sent to the ApC, the CAB shall have the opportunity to file EOF to the Approval Report according to the timelines specified in clause 12.1.
- 21.3 Within 10 calendar days of receipt of the report, the ApC shall communicate its decision to ASI.
- 21.4 Within 5 calendar days of the decision of the ApC, ASI shall notify the CAB of the Withdrawal in writing. The notice of Withdrawal shall include the Effective Date of Withdrawal, a clear statement of the reasons for the decision and the final Approval Report.
- 21.5 The CAB may appeal the Withdrawal Decision in accordance with the ASI ASI Challenge & Appeals Procedure (ASI-PRO-20-103).
- 21.6 ASI shall make public notice of the Withdrawal decision on its website.
- 21.7 Upon confirmation of Withdrawal of Approval or termination of the ASI service agreement, the CAB shall:
 - 21.7.1 immediately cease all ASI Approved Certification Activities;
 - 21.7.2 provide to ASI within 5 calendar days a list of all clients affected, including contact information for each client;
 - 21.7.3 inform - within 15 calendar days - all subcontractors, affiliates, partners and clients in writing of the Withdrawal of Approval and its related implications (e.g. requirement for client to return certificate, process of transfer to other CABs, etc.);
 - 21.7.4 provide evidence to ASI of having contacted all of the above within 5 calendar days of the contact;
 - 21.7.5 cease making reference to its Approved status and discontinue to use the ASI marks;
 - 21.7.6 return the Approval Certificate to ASI, if a printed copy was obtained.
- 21.8 Unless there are SO Requirements allowing a different period, CAB certificates existing at the time of Withdrawal may remain valid for a period of 90 days, subject to confirmation by ASI, to permit CHs to enter into an agreement with another Approved CAB. The ASI OD may grant an extension of this transition period.
- 21.9 A withdrawn Approval cannot be reinstated. If a CAB wishes to be approved again, it must apply for initial Approval as per section 11.
- 21.10 For a period of 24 months from the date of the Withdrawal notification, ASI may choose not to accept applications from a CAB from which Approval has been withdrawn or from a new entity linked and/or substantially staffed with personnel associated with a CAB with a withdrawn Approval.
- 21.11 Clauses 21.1-21.6 do not apply in case of voluntary CAB withdrawal.

22. COST OF APPROVAL

- 22.1 Approved and applicant CABs shall pay fees as shown in the current Fee schedule (ASI-INF-20-124).

- 22.2 Payment of any invoice is due within 30 days of the issue date. A monthly 1% interest charge shall be included for each delayed month, backdating to the initial invoice date. This 1% interest shall continue to accumulate until the invoice is paid in full.
- 22.3 If a payment has not been received within 10 days of the original due date a notification shall be sent to the CAB informing them that they are on “financial probation”. A CAB on financial probation may not:
- 22.3.1 apply for or continue with Scope of Approval extension;
 - 22.3.2 continue with the Approval application process;
 - 22.3.3 receive an ASI Initial Approval Letter;
 - 22.3.4 receive an ASI certificate for initial Approval; or
 - 22.3.5 apply for additional ASI programs.

NOTE: While on financial probation, a CAB may continue to operate ASI Approved programs.

- 22.4 Suspension due to non-payment of fees
- 22.4.1 ASI may directly suspend a CAB’s Approval without involvement of the ApC if an invoice and the related interest accumulated remains unpaid for 120 calendar days after the invoice date (90 calendar days past the due date). For applicant CABs, this shall result in the Suspension of the application process.
 - 22.4.2 ASI shall send the CAB written notice of the Suspension decision and information shall be placed on the ASI website. ASI shall also inform the relevant SO.
 - 22.4.3 Suspension shall be lifted promptly, without ApC involvement, upon receipt of payment. For this type of decision, section 19 on Sanctions does not apply nor does the preparation of an Approval Report for the ApC.

23. INFORMATION DISCLOSURE REQUIREMENTS

- 23.1 Copies of all materials and information relating to the CAB’s Certification Activity shall be made available to ASI upon request within the timelines specified in the request.
- 23.2 The CAB shall make all requested documentation available to ASI before an Assessment. This shall be done via the ASI CAB Portal, by giving remote access to the CAB’s Management System or by other mutually agreeable means.
- 23.3 Minimum documents required for each Assessment type and their delivery deadlines are listed below. Other documents may be requested on a case-by-case basis:
- 23.3.1 Office Assessments: no later than 30 days before the Assessment.
 - organigram,
 - list of approved Auditors and personnel involved in relevant programs if not available in the ASI Audit Personnel Registry,
 - Quality Manual, specific program operations procedure / manual and specific program Auditor manual,
 - list of certificates issued if not available in ASI or SO databases.
 - 23.3.2 Witness / Compliance Assessments: no later than 2 weeks before the Assessment
 - Audit plan/agenda,
 - Audit report(s) from the previous Audit(s),
 - CAB procedures for planning and conducting Audits,
 - Complaint files relevant to the sampled Audit.

- 23.4 In the case of Witness Assessments, the CAB shall send confirmed and complete information on Audit date(s), Audit team and sites to be visited for the sample selected by ASI to witness no later than 30 days before the date of the Audit.
- 23.4.1 Upon request, the CAB shall send ASI the list of upcoming CAB Audits within the Scope of Approval for the forthcoming year.
- 23.5 The CAB shall keep all required information fields related to their AOs updated in the ASI CAB Portal. Relevant changes (i.e. new offices and changes of the type of activities offices carry out) shall be entered within 30 days from the date the information has changed.
- 23.6 The CAB shall inform ASI about changes that can have significant impact on how their organization fulfills the necessary requirements and other terms and conditions associated with Approval. Such information should be disclosed to ASI before the changes take place. Failure to notify ASI in a timely manner may result in Sanctions. Significant changes may include, but are not limited to:
- 23.6.1 changes in ownership (legal entity), name, email address, website address, visiting or mailing address, telephone number.
- 23.6.2 organizational changes or restructuring of key management personnel such as administrative (e.g. billing) or technical/program management.
- 23.7 ASI shall evaluate each case and decide whether an additional on-site Assessment is needed to evaluate Conformity with ASI Approval Requirements and with SO Requirements.

24. REVISION OF APPROVAL REQUIREMENTS

24.1 ASI Approval Requirements

- 24.1.1 The CAB shall comply with the current ASI Approval Requirements at all times, including new requirements or changes to them, within the deadlines stipulated by ASI.
- 24.1.2 ASI shall inform the CAB of any changes to the ASI Approval Requirements and the Effective Date of the changes.
- 24.1.3 ASI may conduct public consultations on proposed major modifications to ASI Approval Requirements to request comments by interested parties. Consultation periods for new or revised ASI procedures should be 30 calendar days. In some cases, ASI may modify this deadline.
- 24.1.3.1 A modification is considered major when it significantly affects the working routines of a CAB.
- 24.1.3.2 Minor changes shall not be preceded by a public consultation.

24.2 SO Requirements

- 24.2.1 The SO may decide to change its Certification Scheme at any given time.
- 24.2.2 It is the sole responsibility of the CAB to monitor the SO Requirements it applies for or is approved to and to continually obtain the necessary information about the aforementioned changes to the SO Requirements.
- 24.2.3 ASI shall take the aforementioned changes to SO Requirements into account once they become effective to ensure that ASI's Approval Decision for a Certification

Scheme is always based on the current effective set of rules of that Certification Scheme.

- 24.2.4 ASI shall, depending on the nature and significance of change in SO requirements, determine the assessment approach to be carried out in order to assess the CAB's demonstrated competence in implementing revised SO requirements.

24.2.4.1 All major NCs shall be closed before a revised Approval Certificate annex may be issued.

24.2.4.2 Once transition to the new/revised standard has been successfully evaluated and major NCs are closed, the certificate annex shall be amended with a reference to the new/revised standards.

25. DISPUTES (CHALLENGE, APPEALS, COMPLAINTS AND INCIDENTS)

- 25.1 If the applicant or Approved CAB disagrees with ASI's findings or decisions at any point in the Approval process, they may submit a Challenge or an Appeal. See ASI Challenge & Appeals Procedure (ASI-PRO-20-103) for more details.
- 25.2 If any person or organization wishes to express dissatisfaction to ASI relating to its activities, or those of an Approved CAB or of a certificate holder, they may submit a Complaint. See Complaints Procedure (ASI-PRO-20-104) for more details.
- 25.3 Incidents concerning any reported activity, observation, stakeholder comment or concern that threatens the reputation and/or integrity of the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program and/or its associated Certification Schemes and that are not already considered under the relevant ASI procedures for Complaints and Challenge & Appeals, may be reported (also anonymously) to ASI through various channels. See ASI Incident Handling Procedure (ASI-PRO-20-107) for more details.

26. PUBLIC NOTICE AND INFORMATION

- 26.1 ASI maintains a list of applicant and Approved CABs on its website. This list includes information such as: CAB's name, address, Approval Status, ASI Code, Accreditation status (via Participating AB) and Accreditation Code issued by participating AB, technical/geographical scope, date of initial Approval, certificate of Approval, ASI Code, records of Assessments and Assessment Reports and a history of Suspensions, as well as contact data as specified by the CAB (main contact name, address, email address, phone number and website).
- 26.2 ASI may publish Assessment Reports to the extent permitted by the ASI Assurance Service Agreement.
- 26.3 ASI may publish a summary of CAB performance grades on its website. See Appraisal Procedure (ASI-PRO-20-256) for details.

27. TRANSFER OF APPROVAL

- 27.1 If an Approved CAB ("transferor CAB") wishes to transfer its Approval to another CAB ("transferee CAB"), which is not ASI Approved for the relevant Certification Scheme, the CAB shall apply for ASI Approval under section 10.

- 27.2 If the transferee CAB: a) is under common ownership and control as the transferor CAB, or b) has been a subcontractor of the transferor CAB and has managed a substantial part of the Certification Activities under the relevant Approval for the previous 18 months, ASI may apply a simplified Approval transfer process, which shall be communicated to the CAB in writing, on a case by case basis.
- 27.3 In the case of minor changes (e.g., change of CAB's name) that do not involve transfer of Approval to another legal entity, it is at ASI's discretion to note the changes on the basis of submitted documentation.
- 27.4 The transferee CAB shall be responsible for closing all open NCs from the transferor CAB.

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